

ZERO SUM RPG SCENARIO: 003 - THE SILENT ALGORITHM



REAL-WORLD INSPIRATION

Based on the highly secretive world of High Frequency Trading (HFT) and the risk of algorithmic "flash crashes" engineered by hostile state actors.

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BACKGROUND

A rogue quantitative hedge fund has deployed an illegal, highly aggressive AI trading algorithm on a direct-access server physically located inside the Frankfurt Stock Exchange data center. The algorithm is designed to execute a cascading short-sell attack that will artificially crash the European energy market within 48 hours, enriching the Syndicate by billions.

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THE ZERO SUM TWIST

The server room is a sterile, hyper-secure environment. It uses an acoustic detection system. Any noise above 45 decibels (a loud whisper, a dropped tool, or heavy footsteps) triggers the silent alarm, locking the vault doors and deploying armed, gas-mask-wearing tactical response units. The players must infiltrate the data center, locate the specific server blade out of thousands of identical ones, and physically install a logic bomb without making a sound.

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ZERO SUM CONSISTENCY MATRIX (ZSCM)

- **E (Lethality Expectation) = 7:** If the acoustic alarm trips, the response team uses lethal force and tear gas.
- **R (Resource Scarcity) = 8:** Players cannot use any standard breaching tools, explosives, or firearms due to the acoustic sensors.
- **I (Intel Asymmetry) = 5:** Finding the correct server blade requires high-level Tech checks on the fly.
- **D (Collateral Damage Risk) = 5:** The facility is mostly empty of civilians at night, but destroying the wrong server could crash innocent pension funds.

Total ZSCM Score = 25/30 (High Tension Stealth).

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KEY NPCS & OBSTACLES

- **The Acoustic Grid:** An ever-present environmental threat. Movement speed is halved.
- **The SysAdmin:** A single, overworked IT technician working the night shift who might wander into the aisle at any moment.

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OBJECTIVE

1. Bypass the biometric security at the data center entrance.
2. Navigate the server aisles in absolute silence.
3. Identify the rogue HFT blade.

4. Upload the counter-virus and extract before the morning shift arrives.